

Botany short course 2026

Flowers

Max Carter-Brown

Anglia Ruskin University

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- Evolutionarily derived from leaves
- Contain the megaspores (ovaries) and microspores (pollen)
- Much variation but exist as 3-4 'whorls'

Flower characters you will classify

- Sepals (or calyx)

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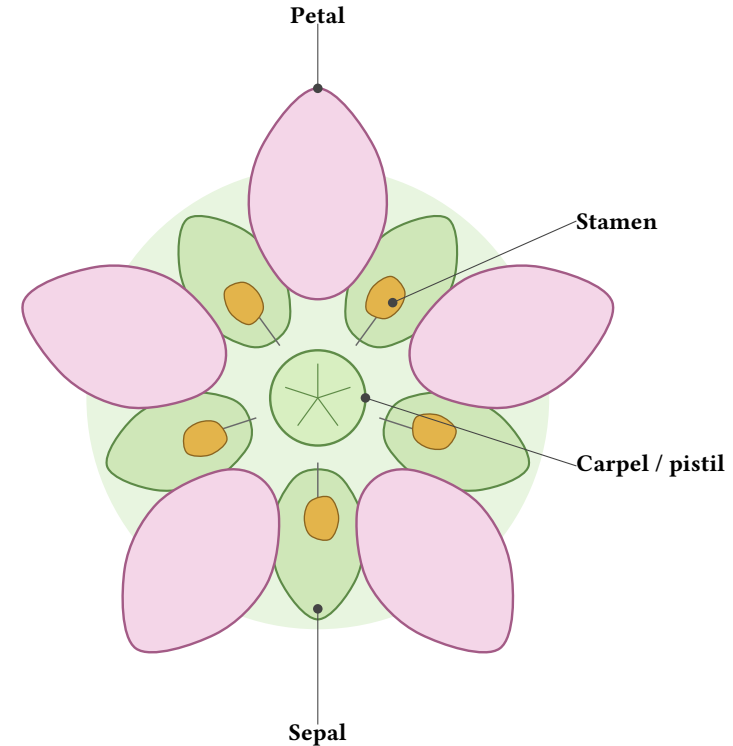
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- Petals (or corolla); tepals
(undifferentiated perianth)

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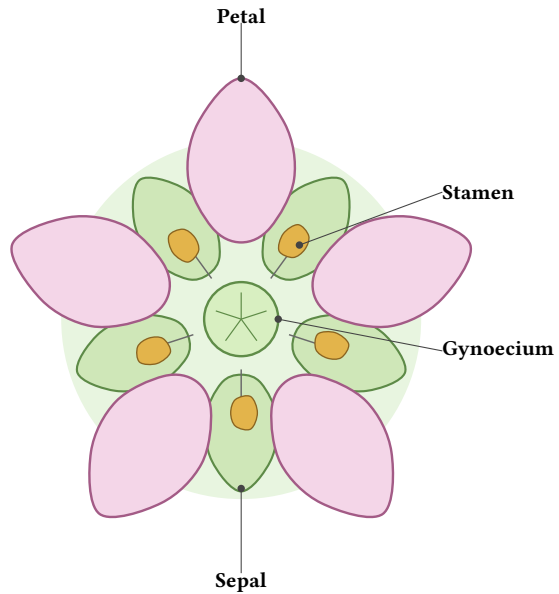
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androecium)

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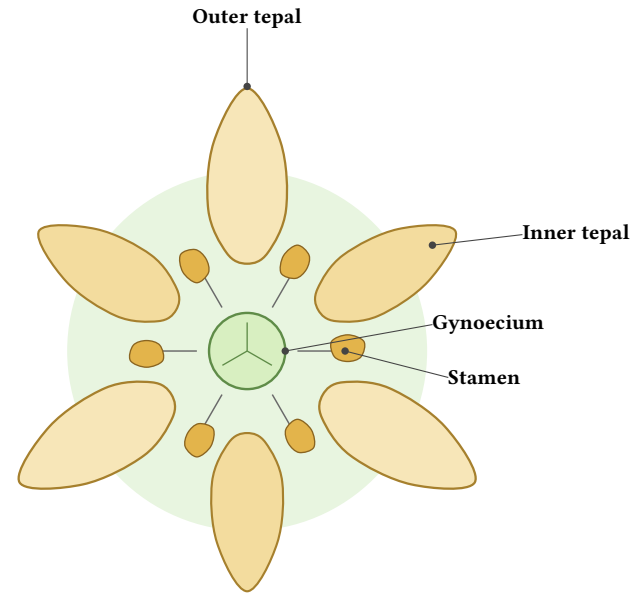
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- Stamens (anthers + filament; androecium)
- Carpels (ovary + style + stigma; pistil)



Idealised flower top view

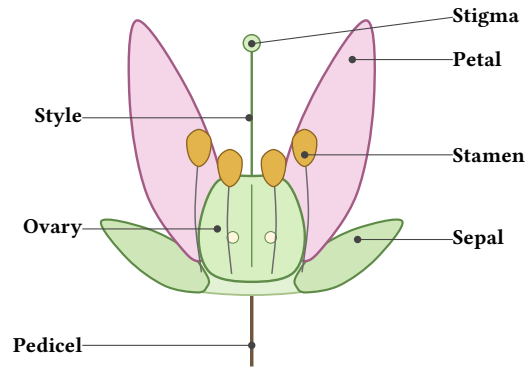


Idealised dicot flower (top view)

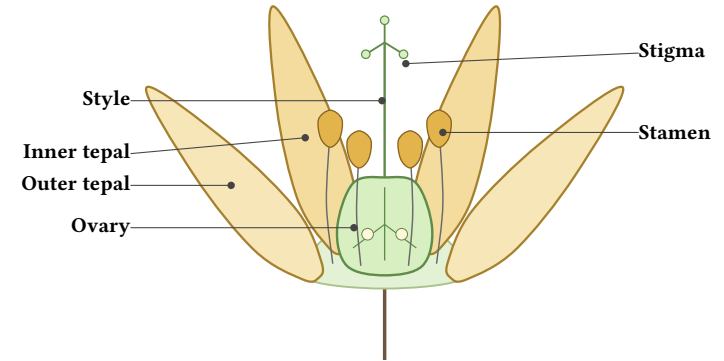


Idealised monocot flower (top view)

Idealised flower cross-section

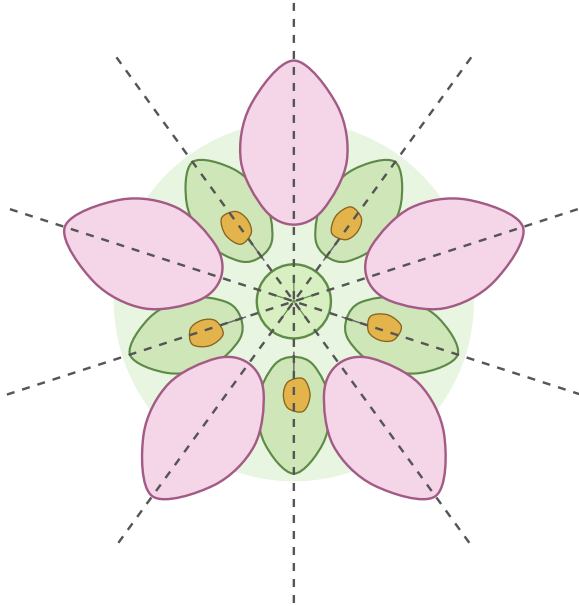


Idealised dicot flower

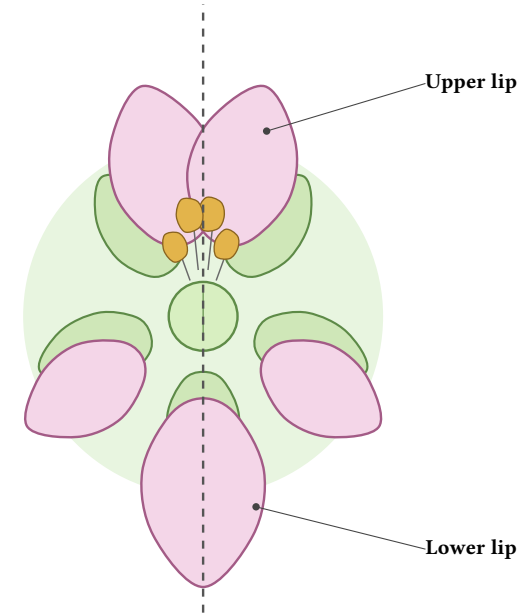


Idealised monocot flower

Floral symmetry



Actinomorphic — radially symmetrical
e.g. *Ranunculus*, *Rosa*



Zygomorphic — bilaterally symmetrical
e.g. *Lamium*, *Digitalis*

Activity — Flower observation

You have a selection of flowers.

1. Is the flower solitary, or part of an inflorescence?
2. Count the parts of each whorl
3. Are petals free or fused?
4. Is the flower radially or bilaterally symmetric?
5. Dissect carefully if needed — lay parts on card

Worksheet provided separately

What to record

Flower characters	
Sepals	Count — note if joined or free
Petals	Count — note if free or fused into a tube
Stamens	Count — note if same number as petals or different
Carpels	Count if visible — superior or inferior ovary?
Symmetry	Radial (actinomorphic) or bilateral (zygomorphic)
Notes	Colour · scent · spur · nectary · hairy?